



THE FUTURE

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IT'S A DIFFERENT India from yore, at least in automotive parlance. And we're not talking 1991 (economic liberalisation). We're talking merely 10-12 years ago. India was a 'small car' country. That was when a bunch of premium hatchbacks were launched by other companies to take on the then matchless Maruti Swift. That they didn't last is beside the point. What their appearance did was bring about a transformation in the optics of what car you should buy, and premium hatchbacks began to rule the roads.

Around the same time, another seed was planted, a seed that has now blossomed fully. SUVs were sold by Tata Motors (Safari, Sumo) and Mahindra & Mahindra (Boloro, Scorpio) for donkey's years. The first real challenge to their dominance came from the Renault Duster in 2012. Companies like Kia and MG Motor have launched only SUVs in India, despite having other configurations in their arsenal. Today, when you roll your car out of your garage and onto the highway, you're practically surrounded by SUVs. Not surprisingly, the SUV has now overtaken premium hatchbacks in sales.

About three years ago, another seismic shift started taking shape with the launch of the MG Hector, which boasted of "Internet Inside". Today, cars boast features and snazzy tech gizmos that make you wonder if it is a car or a computer on wheels.

There are challenges before other segments of the automobile industry, too. Read about how India's auto ancillary companies, many of whom have built huge businesses based on exports, are dealing with the impact of the Russia-Ukraine conflict. Also read about commercial vehicles and their journey on the comeback trail.

In the midst of all this, the biggest shift of all is to electric vehicles. Of course, to call it a 'shift' would perhaps be premature, because the journey for EVs in India has just begun. There are many, many challenges and bottlenecks to overcome.

Enjoy the package.

